

UNIT IX



The Fire and the Dream

The Civil Rights Movement & the Era of Movements · 1954–1975

US.78

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ESSENTIAL QUESTION

For a century after slavery ended, America had written 'liberty and justice for all' on paper and then denied it, in law, to millions of its own people. This unit is about the generation that finally forced the country to keep its word — not by waiting, but by marching, sitting in, riding buses, and being willing to bleed for it. How does a people with almost no power move a whole nation? And once one group pries the door open, who walks through it next?

A hundred years after the Civil War freed the enslaved, America still had not delivered on its own words. In much of the country, Black Americans could not eat at the same lunch counter, attend the same school, or freely cast a vote — all of it legal, all of it enforced. This unit is about the generation that refused to wait any longer, and did something extraordinary: with almost no power — no army, no wealth, no vote in many places — they moved the most powerful nation on earth. They did it by putting their bodies on the line, over and over, and letting the whole country watch on television what segregation actually looked like. You'll travel with people who lived it. Marcus, the war hero who waited a lifetime. Etta, a Nashville college student who sits down at a 'whites-only' counter and doesn't get up. And in the end, Barbara, Cruz, and Wilma — a woman, a farmworker, and a Native activist who take the civil-rights playbook and open doors of their own. Tennessee is at the very center of this story: the Clinton 12, the Nashville sit-ins, and, at its most tragic, a balcony in Memphis. The question underneath it all: how do you make a country finally keep a promise?

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you meet a veteran, a student, and the activists who followed before you meet a law.
- Multiple perspectives — the courtroom and the street, King and Malcolm X, and the many movements one struggle inspired.
- Primary sources — Brown, King's 'Dream,' the great laws, and the movement's unforgettable photographs.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- Power from below — the unit's spine: how people with little power moved a nation.
- The Arc of the Union — plot the movement's hard-won climbs and violent setbacks on the trajectory you're building.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Marcus, 45
The American South



Etta, 20
Nashville, Tennessee



Barbara, 45
An American suburb



Cruz, 19
California's Central
Valley



Wilma, 22
The northern Plains
and the city

Spread 1 • US.78

Analyze *Brown v. Board of Education* and the fierce, sometimes violent struggle to enforce school desegregation.

 Nine words on a courtroom wall: 'Equal Justice Under Law.' For sixty years, the Supreme Court had said segregation was just fine — 'separate but equal,' they called it, though it was never equal. Then in 1954, in one unanimous decision, the same Court said the opposite: separating children by race is wrong, and the Constitution forbids it. It was a legal earthquake. But a ruling is just words on paper until someone enforces it — and enforcing this one would take soldiers, and the courage of a few teenagers walking into a screaming mob.

Archive lands the crew outside a high school ringed by soldiers and a furious crowd. 'The highest court in the land said these kids can go to this school,' she says. 'Now watch how far some people will go to stop them — and how much courage it takes just to walk through a door.'

INSTITUTION

Brown v. Board • the law changes

For decades, segregation hid behind a Supreme Court ruling called *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1896), which said 'separate but equal' facilities were constitutional. In practice, Black schools got a fraction of the funding — separate, never equal. Then the NAACP's lawyers, led by Thurgood Marshall, brought the case of *Brown v. Board of Education*, and in 1954 a unanimous Supreme Court declared that 'separate educational facilities are inherently unequal' and that school segregation violated the Constitution. It was one of the most important rulings in American history — the legal foundation the entire Civil Rights Movement would build on. The words had changed. Now came the hard part.



ERA-FRIEND

Marcus • a father at the schoolhouse door

Marcus fought fascism as a Tuskegee Airman and came home to a country that still made his children attend separate, underfunded schools. When Brown comes down, he weeps — and then he watches what enforcement really means. When Black students try to integrate, mobs scream, governors call out state troops to block them, and at Little Rock in 1957 it takes the 101st Airborne Division, sent by President Eisenhower, to walk nine Black teenagers safely into Central High School. Marcus knows these children are braver than any soldier he flew with. And he knows the ugliest truth Brown exposed: the law can change in an afternoon, but the hatred it confronts does not.

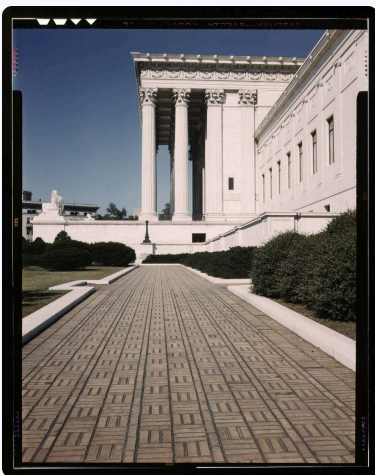


📷 U.S. Army soldiers of the 101st Airborne escort one of the Little Rock Nine to Central High School in 1957, after the governor tried to block integration.

'101st Airborne Division escorts the Little Rock Nine, Central High School, Little Rock, Arkansas.' Photograph, September 1957. Public domain.

💡 This is the 101st Airborne escorting one of the Little Rock Nine into school in 1957 — U.S. soldiers protecting Black teenagers from other Americans. Ask: it took the Army to let nine kids attend a public school. What does that tell you about the difference between changing a law and changing a country?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



The U.S. Supreme Court building, its motto 'Equal Justice Under Law' carved above the door — where *Brown v. Board of Education* struck down school segregation in 1954.

In plain words: For decades, the Supreme Court's *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1896) ruling allowed 'separate but equal' segregation — but Black facilities were never really equal. In *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954), the Court reversed itself, ruling unanimously that segregated schools are unconstitutional. It was a huge legal victory and the foundation of the Civil Rights Movement. But enforcing it was violent and hard: when Black students tried to integrate schools, mobs and even state governors tried to stop them, and at Little Rock (1957) President Eisenhower had to send the Army to protect the Little Rock Nine.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee was on the front line of school integration — a year before Little Rock. In 1956, twelve Black students known as the Clinton 12 became the first to integrate a state-supported public high school in the South, at Clinton, Tennessee. They faced mobs so violent that the governor had to send the National Guard and tanks to their small town. The Clinton 12 walked into history through a wall of hatred, making Tennessee one of the earliest and hardest battlegrounds of the fight to make *Brown* real.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Legal school segregation denied Black children an equal education across much of the country.
- **Head out of the sand:** NAACP lawyers, Black families, and the students who volunteered to integrate hostile schools.
- **Voice raised:** Court challenges (*Brown*) and the courage of students walking into segregated schools.
- **Government response:** The Supreme Court struck down segregation; presidents used federal troops to enforce it against state resistance.
- **Still unfinished:** Many schools remained segregated in practice for decades, and educational inequality persists.

✓ **Check:** Explain what *Brown v. Board of Education* decided and why it mattered. Then explain why the ruling was so hard to enforce, using Little Rock or the Clinton 12 as evidence.

Show what you know:

- Write the letter one of the Clinton 12 or Little Rock Nine might send a friend the night before the first day of school.
- Explain the difference between changing a law and changing a society, using *Brown* as your example.

- Debate: was Brown a triumph, given how hard it was to enforce? Use evidence.
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Spread 2 • US.79

Compare the different strategies civil-rights advocates used — legal challenges, nonviolence, and self-determination.

 You and your friends all want the same thing — justice — but you can't agree on how to get it. One says work through the courts, patiently, case by case. One says fill the streets with peaceful protest and let the world see. One says stop asking your oppressor for permission and build your own power. Who's right? That argument wasn't just a debate; it was the beating heart of the Civil Rights Movement, and the fact that there was more than one answer was a strength, not a weakness.

Archive gathers the crew as three very different leaders' voices play over one another. 'Every movement argues with itself about how to win,' she says. 'Don't look for the one right answer today. Look at what each strategy could do that the others couldn't — and why the movement needed all of them.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Thurgood Marshall • win it in the courts

Thurgood Marshall believed the way to kill segregation was to beat it with its own laws. As the NAACP's chief lawyer, he argued case after case before the Supreme Court — winning 29 of them, including *Brown* — patiently dismantling the legal architecture of Jim Crow one ruling at a time. His approach was disciplined, slow, and unglamorous, and it produced some of the movement's most permanent victories, because a Supreme Court ruling is the law of the land. In 1967 Marshall became the first Black justice on the very Court where he'd won so much. His strategy proved that the movement was fought and won in courtrooms, not only in the streets.

PRIMARY VOICE

Martin Luther King Jr. • nonviolence as a force

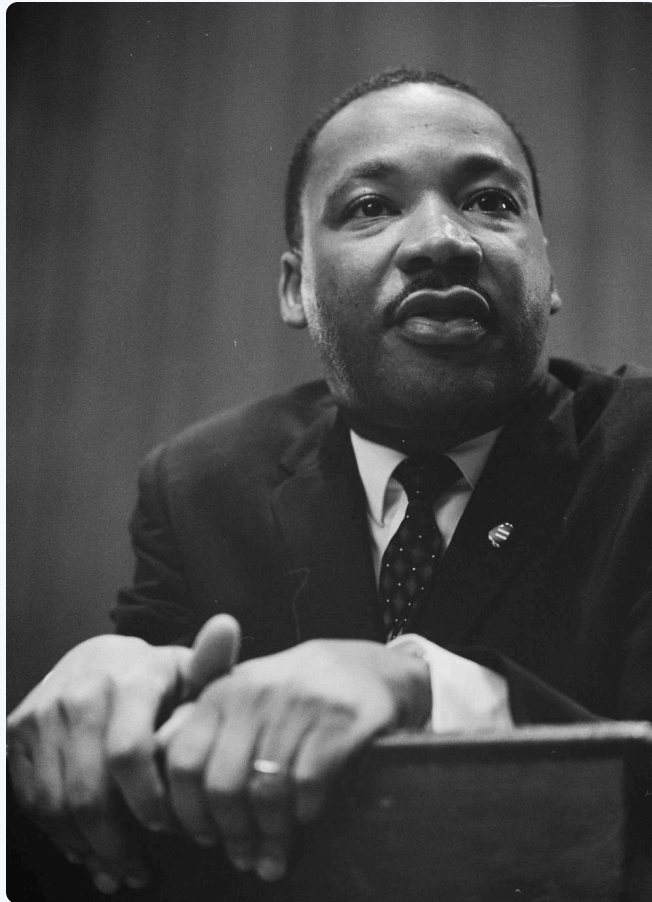
Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. took a different road: nonviolent direct action. Rooted in Christian faith and Gandhi's example, King and activists like Rosa Parks confronted injustice openly and peacefully — boycotts, marches, sit-ins — and, crucially, refused to strike back when attacked. The strategy was not passive; it was a deliberate weapon. By letting the world watch peaceful people be beaten, it exposed the raw brutality of segregation and forced a watching nation to take a side. King became the movement's most famous voice, and in 1964 won the Nobel Peace Prize. Nonviolence turned the movement's suffering into moral power.

PRIMARY VOICE**Malcolm X • pride, power, and self-defense**

Malcolm X challenged them both. He argued that asking politely for rights, and turning the other cheek while being beaten, asked too much and delivered too slowly. Instead he preached Black pride, self-determination, and control of Black communities, and insisted on the right to self-defense 'by any means necessary.' His voice was sharper and more militant than King's, and it spoke to the anger of Black Americans, especially in Northern cities, who were tired of waiting. His views kept evolving until his assassination in 1965. Malcolm X gave the movement a second, harder edge — and a reminder that dignity includes the refusal to beg.

**ERA-FRIEND****Marcus • the man in the middle**

Marcus, the aging veteran, feels all three pulling at him. Marshall's courtroom wins are real but agonizingly slow — Marcus is not a young man anymore. King's nonviolence stirs his soul, but every time he watches a peaceful protester get clubbed, something in him screams to fight back, and Malcolm X puts that fury into words. Marcus doesn't land neatly on one answer, and the crew won't make him. His honest verdict is the unit's: the movement won because it had all three — the lawyer, the preacher, and the prophet of self-respect — and a country can be moved from more than one direction at once.



📷 Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. at a 1964 press conference — the best-known leader of the movement and its apostle of nonviolent protest.

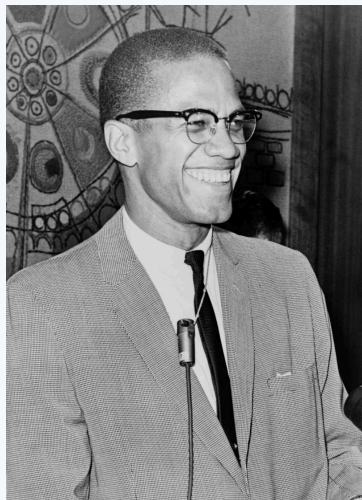
'Martin Luther King Jr. at a press conference.' Photograph, March 26, 1964. Public domain.

💡 This is Dr. King in 1964, the year he won the Nobel Peace Prize. Ask: King's nonviolence deliberately let the world watch peaceful people be attacked. Why would choosing NOT to fight back be one of the most powerful weapons a movement ever used?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Thurgood Marshall, the NAACP's chief lawyer, who won *Brown v. Board* and later became the first Black Supreme Court Justice.



Malcolm X in 1964 — a leader who preached Black pride, self-

determination, and self-defense, giving the movement a sharper, second voice.

In plain words: Civil-rights leaders disagreed about how to win, and that gave the movement more than one voice. Thurgood Marshall fought in the courts, winning 29 Supreme Court cases including *Brown* (and later becoming the first Black justice). Martin Luther King Jr. and Rosa Parks used nonviolent direct action — peaceful protest that refused to strike back — to expose segregation's cruelty and win public support. Malcolm X preached Black pride, self-determination, and self-defense 'by any means necessary,' a sharper approach for those tired of waiting. The movement succeeded partly because it used all of these at once.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee helped teach the movement how to fight without fists. The Highlander Folk School trained civil-rights leaders — including Rosa Parks — and in Nashville, the Rev. James Lawson ran disciplined workshops in nonviolent resistance that shaped a whole generation of student activists. The philosophy that would fill lunch counters and highways across the South was, in large part, taught and rehearsed in Tennessee.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A powerless, oppressed people needed to move a resistant nation toward justice.
- **Head out of the sand:** Lawyers, ministers, students, and militants who each chose a way to fight.
- **Voice raised:** Litigation, nonviolent protest, and movements for Black pride and self-determination.
- **Government response:** Courts and eventually Congress responded to the combined legal and moral pressure.
- **Still unfinished:** The debate over how oppressed people should pursue justice continues in every movement.

✓ **Check:** Compare the strategies of Thurgood Marshall, Martin Luther King Jr., and Malcolm X. What could each accomplish that the others could not? Why might a movement benefit from having more than one strategy?

Show what you know:

- Make a three-column chart comparing Marshall, King, and Malcolm X: goal, method, and biggest strength.
- Write the debate Marcus has in his own head about which strategy to follow — steelman all three.
- Debate: which strategy did the most to end segregation? Argue it while respecting the others.

Spread 3 • US.80

Analyze how the Montgomery Bus Boycott and the student sit-ins used disciplined nonviolent action to break segregation — with Nashville as a national model.

🔊 A tired seamstress refuses to give up her seat, and a whole city stops riding the buses for a year. College students dress in their Sunday best, sit down at a 'whites-only' lunch counter, and calmly keep sitting while people pour ketchup on their heads and drag them off their stools — and they do not fight back, and they come back the next day, and the day after that. This was the genius of the movement: ordinary people, extraordinarily disciplined, turning their own dignity into an unstoppable force.

Archive drops the crew into a Nashville drugstore where students sit straight-backed at a lunch counter as a crowd jeers. Etta is among them, hands folded, terrified and calm. 'Watch closely,' Archive says. 'This is what courage actually looks like — not fighting back when everything in you wants to.'

INSTITUTION

Montgomery • the power of saying no

It started on a bus. In 1955, Rosa Parks was arrested in Montgomery, Alabama, for refusing to give up her seat to a white passenger. In response, the city's Black residents — who rode those buses every day to get to work — simply stopped. For over a year they walked, carpooled, and organized, choking the bus company's income, until in 1956 the Supreme Court ruled bus segregation unconstitutional. The Montgomery Bus Boycott, led by a young Dr. King, proved something powerful: a community with little money and no political power still controlled one thing — its own participation — and could bring an unjust system to its knees by withdrawing it.



ERA-FRIEND

Etta · sitting down for her rights

Etta, now a college student in Nashville, joins the sit-in movement — and it terrifies her. Trained by the Rev. James Lawson in the strict discipline of nonviolence, she and her fellow students dress neatly, sit at 'whites-only' lunch counters, and politely ask to be served. When they're refused, they simply stay. People scream at them, burn them with cigarettes, drag them from their stools, and have them arrested — and the students never raise a hand, because the whole strategy depends on the ugliness landing on the attackers, not them. It is the hardest thing Etta has ever done. And Nashville's campaign is so disciplined that in May 1960 the city becomes one of the first in the South to desegregate its lunch counters.



 Nashville student leaders Diane Nash and Bernard Lafayette during the 1960 Nashville sit-in campaign — one of the movement's most disciplined and successful.

'Diane Nash and Bernard Lafayette, Nashville sit-in leaders.' Photograph, April 9, 1960. Public domain.

 These are Nashville student leaders Diane Nash and Bernard Lafayette during the 1960 sit-in campaign. Ask: these were students not much older than you, facing arrest and violence with total discipline. Where do you think that kind of courage and self-control comes from — and could you do it?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



More than 250,000 people fill the National Mall for the March on Washington, August 28, 1963, where Dr. King gave the 'I Have a Dream' speech.



Marchers carrying American flags on the Selma-to-Montgomery march, 1965, held after state troopers beat peaceful marchers on 'Bloody Sunday.'

In plain words: The movement won by disciplined nonviolent action. In 1955, after Rosa Parks was arrested for refusing to give up her bus seat, Montgomery's Black community boycotted the buses for over a year, until the Supreme Court struck down bus segregation (1956) — proving the power of economic protest. Then students launched sit-ins: dressing neatly, sitting at 'whites-only' lunch counters, and refusing to leave or fight back even when attacked. Nashville's sit-in movement, trained by James Lawson, was one of the most disciplined in the country and desegregated the city's lunch counters by May 1960.

● **Tennessee:** Nashville set the standard for the whole country. Trained in James Lawson's nonviolence workshops, Nashville students — including Diane Nash, John Lewis, and Bernard Lafayette — ran one of the most organized and disciplined sit-in campaigns in America, and in May 1960 Nashville became one of the first major Southern cities to begin desegregating its lunch counters. The leaders forged at those Nashville counters would go on to help lead the entire national movement.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Segregation excluded Black Americans from buses, lunch counters, and public life.
- **Head out of the sand:** Rosa Parks, Nashville and other student activists, and communities ready to sacrifice.
- **Voice raised:** Economic boycotts and disciplined nonviolent sit-ins that exposed injustice.
- **Government response:** Courts struck down bus segregation; cities like Nashville desegregated public accommodations under sustained pressure.
- **Still unfinished:** Ending legal segregation in one city or on one bus line was only the start of a national fight.

✓ **Check:** Explain how the Montgomery Bus Boycott and the sit-ins each used nonviolent tactics to fight segregation. Why did refusing to fight back make these protests so effective? What made Nashville's campaign a model?

Show what you know:

- Write the nonviolence 'rules' Etta would have to follow at the counter, and why each one matters strategically.
 - Design a poster recruiting students to a disciplined sit-in, making the case for nonviolence.
 - Debate: was nonviolent discipline the movement's greatest strength, or did it ask too much of protesters? Use evidence.
-

Spread 4 • US.80

Analyze how the Freedom Rides and the March on Washington used courage and mass action to force the nation to confront segregation.

🔔 Get on a bus, ride it into the Deep South, and dare the mob to stop you. That's what the Freedom Riders did — Black and white activists riding together to test whether the law against segregated travel was actually being obeyed. A firebombed bus was the answer. And two years later, a quarter of a million people stood before the Lincoln Memorial to hear four words that would echo forever: 'I have a dream.' This is the movement at its bravest and its most hopeful — putting bodies on the line, and lifting a whole nation's eyes.

Archive shows the crew a bus in flames on an Alabama roadside, then lifts them above an ocean of people at the Lincoln Memorial. 'Terror and hope, two years apart,' she says. 'The movement had to be willing to face the fire before it could stand in front of the whole world and dream out loud. Watch both.'



ERA-FRIEND

Etta • keeping the Freedom Rides alive

In 1961, activists called Freedom Riders board interstate buses — Black and white riders sitting together — to test whether bus stations across the South were really desegregated as the Supreme Court had ordered. The South's answer is savage: near Anniston, Alabama, a mob firebombs a bus and beats the riders. The original riders are battered nearly to stopping. And here is where Etta's Nashville matters most: when it looks like the violence has won, Nashville students led by Diane Nash refuse to let the rides die, organizing fresh volunteers to take the wounded riders' places. Etta is one of them, climbing aboard knowing exactly what waits. Their refusal to quit saves the campaign — and proves the movement cannot be beaten by fear.

GROUP

The March on Washington · a dream out loud

Two years later came the movement's grandest moment. On August 28, 1963, more than 250,000 people — Black and white, from all over the country — gathered at the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom, the largest protest in American history to that point. There, before the Lincoln Memorial, Dr. King delivered the 'I Have a Dream' speech, holding up a vision of an America where his children 'will not be judged by the color of their skin but by the content of their character.' It was not just soaring words; it was strategic pressure, a peaceful show of force so vast that Congress could no longer look away. The march helped push the Civil Rights Act toward passage.



📷 More than 250,000 people fill the National Mall for the March on Washington, August 28, 1963, where Dr. King gave the 'I Have a Dream' speech.

'March on Washington — crowd at the Reflecting Pool.' Photograph, August 28, 1963. Public domain.

💡 This is the crowd at the March on Washington on August 28, 1963 — roughly a quarter of a million people at the Lincoln Memorial. Ask: the Freedom Rides and marches like this put ordinary people's bodies on the line and forced the nation to watch. Why was disciplined, visible mass action so powerful — and how did images like this move the country?

In plain words: In 1961, Freedom Riders — Black and white activists riding buses together — tested whether Southern bus stations were really desegregated. Mobs attacked them and firebombed a bus near Anniston, Alabama. When the violence nearly stopped the rides, Nashville students led by Diane Nash organized new riders to continue, saving the campaign. Two years later, the March on Washington (August 28, 1963) gathered over 250,000 people, where Dr. King gave his 'I Have a Dream' speech. The march helped push Congress toward the Civil Rights Act of 1964.

● **Tennessee:** When the Freedom Rides nearly died under mob violence, Tennessee kept them alive. Nashville students, led by Diane Nash, refused to let the terror in Alabama end the campaign, organizing fresh riders to continue into danger. It was one of the movement's most decisive moments — proof that it could not be beaten by fear — and it came out of the disciplined student movement that Nashville had built.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Segregation persisted in travel and public life despite court rulings, defended by violence.
- **Head out of the sand:** Freedom Riders, Nashville student organizers, and the 250,000 who marched on Washington.
- **Voice raised:** Direct action that dared the violence, plus the largest peaceful demonstration in U.S. history.
- **Government response:** Federal authorities were pushed to enforce desegregation and Congress toward the Civil Rights Act.
- **Still unfinished:** Legal victories still had to be won and enforced against continuing resistance.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the Freedom Rides were and how Nashville students kept them going. Then explain the significance of the March on Washington. How did facing violence actually help the movement win support?

Show what you know:

- Write the note Etta leaves for her family the night before she boards a Freedom Ride.
 - Analyze the burning-bus photo: why did the movement's opponents give it such a powerful weapon?
 - Respond to 'I Have a Dream' with your own short paragraph on the America you would dream out loud.
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Spread 5 • US.81

Analyze the great civil-rights laws — the Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965 — and the Selma campaign that forced them.

 Marches and speeches can change hearts, but only a law can change the rules. After a decade of boycotts, sit-ins, beatings, and dreams, the movement finally forced the two most powerful civil-rights laws since the end of slavery through Congress — and it took one more river of blood, on a bridge in Selma, to do it. This is the moment the movement's courage got written into the law of the land, where a governor's hatred could no longer erase it.

Archive brings the crew to a bridge in Selma, then to the White House where a president lifts a pen. 'Watch the sequence,' she says. 'Peaceful marchers get beaten on that bridge, the whole country sees it on television that night, and within months it becomes the law. This is how the movement turned suffering into statutes.'

GROUP

Selma • the bridge that moved a nation

By 1965, the movement had won public accommodations but not the vote — across the South, Black citizens were still blocked from registering by literacy tests, intimidation, and violence. To force the issue, activists marched from Selma toward Montgomery, Alabama. On March 7, 1965 — 'Bloody Sunday' — state troopers attacked the peaceful marchers on the Edmund Pettus Bridge with clubs and tear gas, beating them savagely. Television carried the images into living rooms nationwide that very night, and the country recoiled in horror. The nonviolent strategy had worked once more: the marchers' willingness to be beaten, without striking back, made the case for voting rights more powerfully than any speech.

INSTITUTION

The laws • Jim Crow made illegal

The pressure produced landmark laws that reshaped America. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 outlawed discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or national origin, and banned segregation in public places — the most sweeping civil-rights law since Reconstruction. The Voting Rights Act of 1965 banned literacy tests and sent federal officials to register Black voters where discrimination had blocked them; President Johnson introduced it using the movement's own words, 'We shall overcome.' Add the 24th Amendment ending the poll tax and the 1968 Fair Housing Act, and legal Jim Crow — the whole apparatus of official segregation — was finally dismantled. Words on paper, at last, with the power to change lives.



📷 President Johnson signs the Voting Rights Act of 1965, banning literacy tests and other barriers, with Dr. King and other leaders looking on.

'President Johnson signs the Voting Rights Act of 1965.' Photograph, August 6, 1965. Public domain.

💡 This is President Johnson signing the Voting Rights Act of 1965, with Dr. King looking on. Ask: it took a decade of protest and the beatings at Selma to produce this single signature. What's the relationship between what happens in the streets and what happens at this desk?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



President Lyndon B. Johnson signs the Civil Rights Act of 1964, with Dr. King among those present — the most sweeping civil-rights law since Reconstruction.

In plain words: Protests could change minds, but only laws could change the rules. In 1965, activists marched from Selma toward Montgomery for voting rights; on 'Bloody Sunday' (March 7), state troopers beat the peaceful marchers on the Edmund Pettus Bridge, and the televised images horrified the nation. The result was landmark legislation: the Civil Rights Act of 1964 (banning discrimination and segregation in public places) and the Voting Rights Act of 1965 (banning literacy tests and protecting Black voting), plus the 24th Amendment (ending the poll tax) and the 1968 Fair Housing Act. Together they dismantled legal Jim Crow.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's movement had already helped build the momentum that made these laws possible. The disciplined Nashville campaigns and the leaders they produced — like John Lewis, who would be beaten at the front of the Selma march and later serve decades in Congress — carried the movement from Tennessee's lunch counters all the way to the Edmund Pettus Bridge and the desks where these laws were signed. The victories written into federal law in 1964 and 1965 were built, in part, in Tennessee.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Even after public accommodations opened, Black citizens were still blocked from voting by legal barriers and violence.
- **Head out of the sand:** Voting-rights marchers and organizers willing to be beaten on the Edmund Pettus Bridge.
- **Voice raised:** The Selma march and 'Bloody Sunday,' broadcast nationwide.
- **Government response:** Congress passed the Civil Rights Act (1964) and Voting Rights Act (1965), with federal enforcement.
- **Still unfinished:** Protecting voting rights against new barriers remains an active struggle today.

✓ **Check:** Explain how the Selma marches led to the Voting Rights Act of 1965. Then describe what the Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965 each did. Why were laws necessary, not just protests?

Show what you know:

- Diagram the chain from 'Bloody Sunday' to the Voting Rights Act, marking the role of television.
 - Compare what the Civil Rights Act (1964) and Voting Rights Act (1965) each changed in a two-column chart.
 - Debate: which mattered more to lasting change — the marches or the laws? Argue that they needed each other.
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Spread 6 · US.80, US.81

Analyze the movement's later phase and its cost through the 1968 Memphis sanitation strike and the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr.

🔊 Two words on a sign, held by exhausted men who cleaned a city's garbage for poverty wages: 'I Am a Man.' In 1968, Memphis sanitation workers went on strike simply to be treated as human beings, and the most famous man in the movement came to stand with them. He never left. This is the spread where the movement's dream meets its deepest cost — a balcony in Memphis, Tennessee, and a loss the country has never fully gotten over.

Archive brings the crew to a Memphis street where marchers carry 'I Am a Man' signs. She's quiet. 'By now the movement has won laws most people said were impossible,' she says. 'And it's about to pay the highest price of all, right here in Tennessee. Watch with respect.'



ERA-FRIEND

Etta · the fight isn't finished

By 1968 Etta is a seasoned organizer, and she knows the great laws of 1964 and 1965 didn't end the struggle — they changed its shape. In Memphis, Black sanitation workers, doing brutal, dangerous jobs for poverty pay, go on strike after two men are crushed to death by faulty equipment. Their signs say simply 'I Am a Man' — a demand not just for wages but for dignity. To Etta, Memphis proves the point the whole movement kept making: winning the right to sit at a counter meant little if you still couldn't earn a living wage or be treated as fully human. The movement was turning toward economic justice — the next, harder frontier.

GROUP

Memphis, April 4, 1968 · the cost

Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. came to Memphis to support the striking sanitation workers. On the evening of April 4, 1968, he was assassinated on the balcony of the Lorraine Motel. The news broke the nation's heart and set off grief and unrest in cities across the country. King was thirty-nine years old. His death marked the end of the movement's classic era and remains one of the most painful losses in American history — a reminder that every law, every open door, every protected vote in this unit was purchased at a staggering human price, paid by people who knew it might cost them everything. The dream did not die with him, but the country has never stopped mourning what was taken on that Memphis balcony.

 **Primary source:** In 1968, Memphis sanitation workers struck under the banner 'I Am a Man,' and Dr. King came to support them; he was assassinated at the Lorraine Motel on April 4, 1968 — now the site of the National Civil Rights Museum.

 The strikers' signs didn't demand fancy rights — just to be seen as men. Why might 'I Am a Man' be one of the most powerful protest slogans in American history? And what does it mean that the movement's greatest leader was killed standing with garbage workers?

In plain words: The great laws of 1964–65 didn't end the struggle — they moved it toward economic justice. In 1968, Black sanitation workers in Memphis, Tennessee, went on strike for dignity and fair pay after two workers were killed by unsafe equipment; their signs read 'I Am a Man.' Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. came to support them, and on April 4, 1968, he was assassinated at the Lorraine Motel in Memphis. His death broke the nation's heart, set off grief and unrest, and marked the end of the movement's classic era — a reminder of the terrible price paid for civil-rights progress.

 **Tennessee:** The movement's most tragic hour happened in Tennessee. The Memphis sanitation workers' strike drew Dr. King to the city, and it was on the balcony of Memphis's Lorraine Motel — now the National Civil Rights Museum — that he was assassinated on April 4, 1968. Tennessee, which had helped teach the movement nonviolence and produced some of its bravest students, became the place where it paid its highest price.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Even after legal segregation ended, Black workers still faced poverty wages and denied dignity.
- **Head out of the sand:** Memphis sanitation workers and the leaders, including King, who stood with them.
- **Voice raised:** A workers' strike for dignity ('I Am a Man') backed by the civil-rights movement.
- **Government response:** The strike was eventually settled, but King's assassination and the movement's economic goals went largely unfulfilled.
- **Still unfinished:** Economic justice — a living wage and full dignity for all workers — remains the movement's unfinished frontier.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the Memphis sanitation strike was about and why 'I Am a Man' captured the movement's next goal. Then explain the significance of King's assassination there. What does Memphis 1968 show about the movement's cost and its unfinished work?

Show what you know:

- Write a short, respectful reflection on why 'I Am a Man' still resonates as a demand for dignity.
 - Research the National Civil Rights Museum at the Lorraine Motel and explain why preserving that site matters.
 - Explain how the Memphis strike shows the movement turning from legal rights to economic justice.
-

Spread 7 • US.82

Analyze the related equality movements the civil-rights movement inspired — the American Indian, Chicano/farmworker, and women's movements.

💡 When one group forces a door open, others walk through it. The Black freedom movement didn't just win rights for Black Americans — it handed every excluded group in America a playbook: organize, protest nonviolently, put your dignity on the line, and make the country live up to its promise. Within a few years, farmworkers, women, and Native Americans all picked up that playbook and turned it on their own injustices. The 1960s became the decade America argued, all at once, about who 'we the people' really means.

Archive gathers the crew as three new marches fill the streets — a picket line in a vineyard, a women's march in Washington, a Native occupation on the Plains. 'The movement lit a fire,' she says, 'and the sparks are landing everywhere. Watch three more groups demand what the founders promised them too.'



ERA-FRIEND

Cruz • the fields fight back

Cruz picks grapes in California's Central Valley, where his family has worked for poverty wages, bent double in the heat, his whole life. Then César Chávez and Dolores Huerta build the United Farm Workers and bring the civil-rights playbook to the fields: strikes, marches, and a nationwide boycott asking Americans to stop buying grapes until the growers bargained fairly. Cruz joins the great Delano grape strike, learns Chávez's insistence on nonviolence, and feels something new — that even the poorest, most invisible workers in America could organize and win. The Chicano movement, of which the farmworkers were a part, also demanded respect for Mexican American culture, history, and rights. Cruz stops feeling invisible.



ERA-FRIEND

Barbara · naming the problem

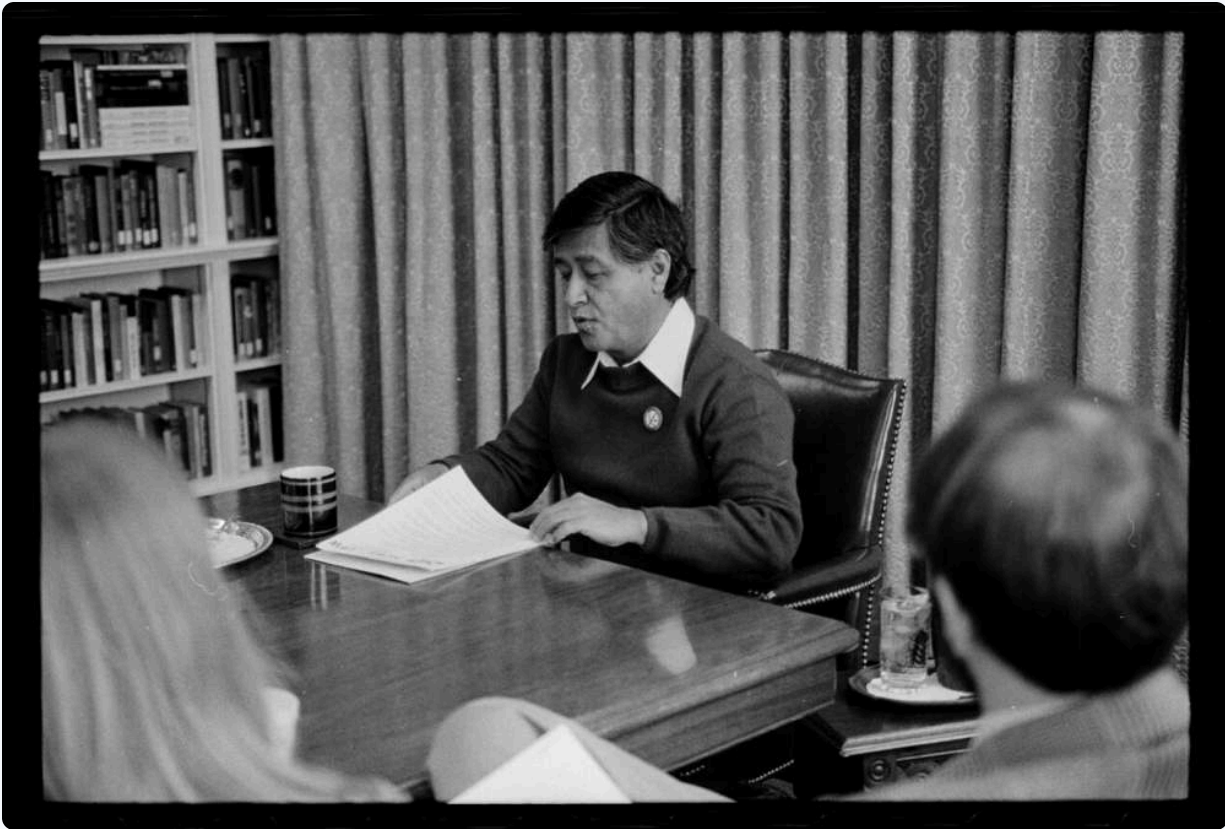
Barbara, the suburban homemaker whose quiet discontent you met in the last unit, finally hears her own feeling named out loud. Writer Betty Friedan called it 'the problem that has no name' — the sense that a woman confined to house and family was being denied a fuller self. Energized by the civil-rights movement's example, Barbara and millions of women build the modern women's movement, forming groups like the National Organization for Women and marching for equal pay, equal opportunity, and control over their own lives. In 1970, on the fiftieth anniversary of women winning the vote, they march in the Women's Strike for Equality. Barbara's private restlessness has become a public movement.



ERA-FRIEND

Wilma · honoring the treaties

Wilma, a young Native woman raised between a reservation and a city, joins the American Indian Movement (AIM), founded in 1968. Native Americans had endured centuries of broken treaties, stolen land, forced assimilation, and erasure — the story that began way back in this course's very first unit. Now, inspired by the era's other movements, AIM demands that the United States honor its treaty obligations, respect tribal sovereignty, and stop trying to erase Native cultures. Through protests and occupations, Wilma and AIM force a country that had nearly written Native people out of its story to reckon with them as living nations. The oldest injustice in American history finds a new, defiant voice.



📷 César Chávez, co-founder of the United Farm Workers, who used nonviolent strikes and boycotts to win rights for mostly Mexican American and Filipino American farm workers.

'César Chávez interview portrait.' Photograph, April 20, 1979. Public domain.

💡 This is César Chávez, who organized farmworkers with the same nonviolent tactics as the civil-rights movement. Ask: Chávez asked ordinary Americans to stop buying grapes to help workers they'd never meet. Why is a boycott such a powerful tool — and would you join one for a cause you believed in?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Marchers in the 1970 Women's Strike for Equality carry banners reading 'Women Demand Equality' — the women's movement borrowing the civil-rights movement's tactics.

In plain words: The Black civil-rights movement inspired other groups to demand equality using the same tactics. César Chávez and Dolores Huerta's United Farm Workers used strikes, marches, and a grape boycott to win rights for mostly Mexican American and Filipino American farmworkers (part of the Chicano movement). The women's movement, led by figures like Betty Friedan and the National Organization for Women, fought sex discrimination and marched for equality (the 1970 Women's Strike for Equality). And the American Indian Movement (AIM, 1968) fought for Native sovereignty and treaty rights. The 1960s expanded the meaning of civil rights for everyone.

● **Tennessee:** The methods these movements borrowed had been sharpened, in part, in Tennessee. The disciplined nonviolence taught in Nashville and at the Highlander Folk School, and modeled by leaders like John Lewis and Diane Nash, became a template that farmworkers, women, and Native activists adapted for their own struggles. The playbook that opened doors across America in these years carried Tennessee's fingerprints — a reminder that a movement's ideas can travel far beyond where they began.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Many excluded groups — farmworkers, women, Native Americans — were still denied full equality and dignity.
- **Head out of the sand:** New generations of organizers who adapted the civil-rights playbook to their own causes.
- **Voice raised:** Strikes and boycotts (UFW), marches and organizations (women's movement), and protests and occupations (AIM).
- **Government response:** Uneven — some legal and workplace gains, many demands still unmet, especially Native treaty rights.
- **Still unfinished:** Full equality for women, workers, Native nations, and others remains an ongoing, unfinished project.

✓ **Check:** Describe the American Indian, Chicano/farmworker, and women's movements, giving one leader or event for each. Explain how they were inspired by the Black civil-rights movement — and why each was also its own distinct struggle.

Show what you know:

- Make a chart of the three movements: who, main tactic, key win, and what they borrowed from civil rights.
 - Write a short 'movement playbook' — the shared tactics an excluded group could use to demand its rights.
 - Debate: is it better to describe these as 'one movement' or 'many movements'? Argue using their similarities and differences.
-

Toward a more perfect union

This is the unit where the 'more perfect union' stops being a hope and becomes a demand. For nine units you've watched the gap between America's promise — liberty and justice for all — and its practice. Here, a generation finally closes part of that gap by force of moral courage, and they do it in the most American way imaginable: by holding the country to its own founding words. Watch the movement win real, permanent victories — the end of legal segregation, the protection of the vote — that make the nation genuinely more perfect than it was. And watch, honestly, what it cost: beatings, bombings, and a bullet on a Memphis balcony. Then watch the door they pried open swing wider, as women, Latinos, and Native Americans walk through it to demand their share of the promise too. The union got more perfect here. It is still, the unit insists, unfinished.

Closing question: The civil-rights movement forced America closer to its founding promise than any moment since Reconstruction — at a terrible cost, and with the work still unfinished. Choose one victory and one thing left undone, and argue how much closer the movement brought the country to 'liberty and justice for all.' Then explain how one later movement (women's, farmworkers', or Native) built on what it started. Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1954	Brown v. Board of Education	The Supreme Court overturns 'separate but equal' and outlaws school segregation.	
1956	The Montgomery Bus Boycott succeeds	A year-long boycott ends bus segregation and launches the movement's mass phase.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1961	The Freedom Rides face the fire	Mobs firebomb a bus, but Nashville students keep the rides going.	
1964	The Civil Rights Act of 1964	Congress outlaws discrimination and segregation in public accommodations.	
1965	The Voting Rights Act of 1965	Selma's 'Bloody Sunday' forces a law protecting the Black vote.	
1968	The assassination of Martin Luther King Jr.	King is killed in Memphis while standing with striking sanitation workers.	
1968	The movement inspires new movements	The Black freedom struggle sparks the farmworker, women's, and Native movements.	